Remote Controller with Fail-Safe Update

Concept of Operations

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1.0 Introduction

1.1 Project Description

1.1.1 Background

Purpose: The System lets an operator on the ground command, monitor, and update a controller in space that nobody can reach, and keeps that controller working between contacts.

Need: A controller that nobody can reach must stay operable, observable, and correctable for its whole life. Operation, observability, and maintenance including in-flight modification over the specified lifetime are three areas a space software specification must cover [3, Annex B, items 5.11–5.13, p. 113].

Worst-Case Failure: A failed update can leave the controller unable to run any firmware and unable to accept new firmware. Without physical access, that state is permanent.

Rationale: The loss has happened. NASA records a mission terminated after an in-flight software upload omitted a patch for a defective countdown timer; its recommendations include test-bed verification of in-flight software updates [4, Lesson 0559, p. 199].

1.1.2 Assumptions and Constraints

C-1 The ground cannot talk to the controller directly. Every command, report, and firmware image passes through the onboard computer.

C-2 All software is built to NASA's software engineering requirements. Rigor per part is set by its software class [5, Sec. 3.5.1, p. 24; App. C].

C-3 One engineer builds and checks the System. No independent team reviews the work.

C-4 The System runs on commercial development boards, not on spacecraft hardware. It can show how the System behaves, not that it would survive launch or space.

A-1 Once launched, physical access to the onboard computer or controller is impossible; all fixes and updates must arrive by radio.

A-2 The controller can lose power at any moment, even halfway through writing new firmware. The System must survive that without losing the controller [2, App. A, Table 2, p. 63].

A-3 The ground can reach the spacecraft only during line-of-sight contact windows **[TBD-5]**. Between contacts the System must work on its own.

A-4 One person operates the ground station. No second person checks a command before it is sent, so the System itself must refuse wrong commands.

A-5 Radiation in space can flip single bits in memory, so stored firmware can change on its own. The System must not run firmware that has changed [2, App. A, Table 2, p. 63].

Note. *A constraint (C) is a limit the System must work within; it is imposed, not chosen. An assumption (A) is a condition taken as true without proof; the design depends on it, and if it proves false the design may be wrong.* ***[TBR-**n**]*** *marks a proposal the author has not yet accepted;* ***[TBD-**n**]*** *marks a value not yet known. Both are listed in App. C.*

1.2 Overview of the Envisioned System

1.2.1 Overview

The System comprises two spatially separated operational segments. The **ground segment** on Earth includes the operator, the mission operations center running ground software, and the ground station antenna [6, Sec. 11.2, p. 305]. The **space segment** in orbit consists of the onboard computer and the controller, which operate without physical access.

Communication between segments is strictly established via a radio link during line-of-sight contact windows [**TBD-5**]. Outside contact windows, the space segment operates autonomously. Within the spacecraft, the onboard computer communicates with the controller over the data link during normal operation. If the controller's main firmware fails to execute, the onboard computer utilizes the reprogramming link to restore functional firmware independently of the controller's primary software. Figure 1 illustrates this segment layout.

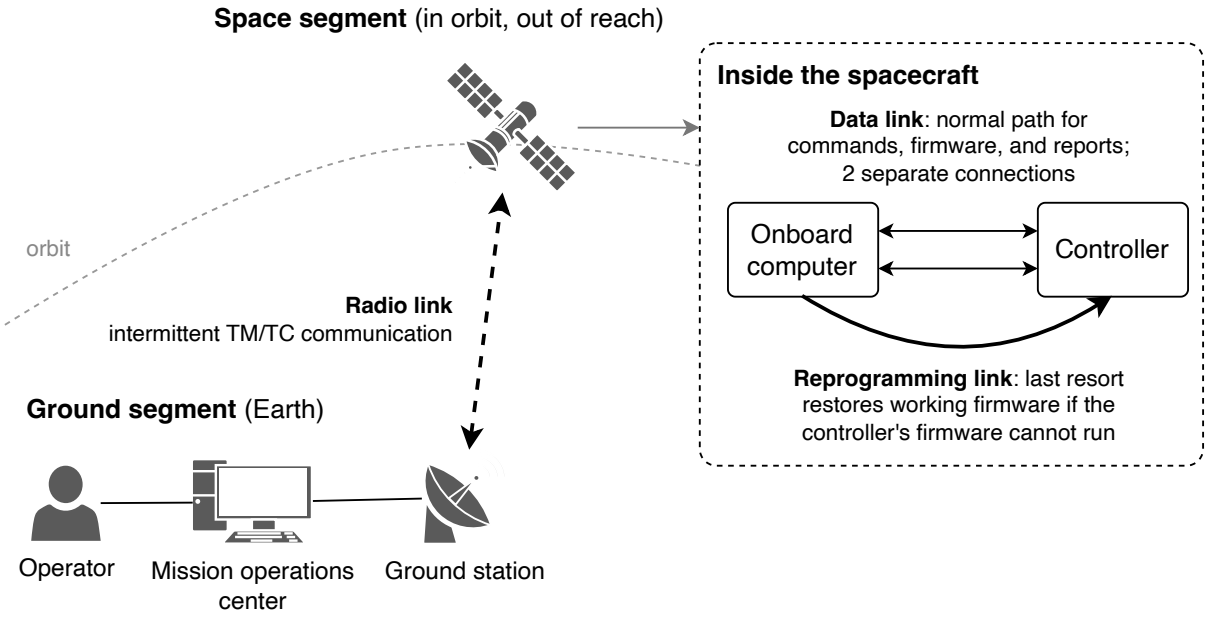


Figure 1: Ground and space segments, joined only by the radio link during contact windows. Inside the spacecraft, the data link handles normal communication, while the reprogramming link restores working firmware if the controller's firmware cannot run.

1.2.2 System Scope

The system context defines the boundary of the System: the system of interest, its users, and the external elements that interface with it [7, Sec. 8.3, p. 24].

Context Element	System Boundary
System of Interest	Onboard computer, controller, ground software in the MOC
Users	Ground operator
External Elements	Radio equipment, spacecraft power supply

- **Enabling systems:** firmware build tools and bench test setups required for development and verification, external to operational scope.
- **In scope:** commanding, telemetry, firmware updates, and autonomous fault handling between contact windows [**TBR-5**].
- **Out of scope:** onboard computer software updates [**TBR-7**], and the radio equipment, which is used as given.

2.0 Documents

2.1 Applicable Documents

[1] NASA, *NASA Systems Engineering Handbook*, NASA/SP-2016-6105 Rev 2, 2016. This outline follows its App. S, pp. 251–253, tailored per its Sec. 3.11.1, p. 34: Section 7.0 not applicable; App. C added for open items per its App. C, pp. 197–198.

2.2 Reference Documents

[2] NASA, *Software Assurance and Software Safety Standard*, NASA-STD-8739.8B, 2022. Off-nominal scenarios cite App. A, Table 2.
[3] ESA, *Space engineering — Software*, ECSS-E-ST-40C Rev. 1, 30 April 2025.
[4] NASA, *Fault Management Handbook*, NASA-HDBK-1002, Draft 2, 2 April 2012. A draft, not a released standard.
[5] NASA, *NASA Software Engineering Requirements*, NPR 7150.2D.
[6] NASA, *State-of-the-Art of Small Spacecraft Technology*, Chapter 11, "Ground Data Systems and Mission Operations", 2026 edition. Ground system architecture in Sec. 11.2 and Fig. 11.2, pp. 305–306.
[7] NASA, *NASA Systems Modeling Handbook for Systems Engineering*, NASA-HDBK-1009A, 12 March 2025.

3.0 Description of Envisioned System

3.1 Needs, Goals and Objectives

NEED A controller that nobody can reach must stay operable, observable and correctable for its whole life.

G-1 **Operability:** the controller keeps running and acts on the operator's commands.
- **O-1** Every valid operator command is executed. Valid means from the operator, allowed in the current state, with possible values, and not expired.
- **O-2** Firmware and commands not from the operator are never acted on.
- **O-3** With one data-link connection lost, commands, telemetry and updates continue.
- **O-4** No fault found between contacts goes unreported [**TBR-5**].

G-2 **Observability:** the ground can know what the System is doing, how healthy it is, and what happened between contacts.
- **O-5** No report is lost without the ground being told.

G-3 **Correctability:** the controller's firmware can be replaced for its whole life without losing the controller.
- **O-6** No update, even one interrupted by a single fault, leaves the controller without runnable firmware.

3.2 Overview of System and Key Elements

Operator The user. Decides and sends commands, releases new firmware, and reads the reports.

Ground software In the mission operations center. Turns the operator's decisions into commands and firmware ready to send, checks them before they leave, and keeps every report received.

Onboard computer Checks commands and firmware and passes them to the controller, stores the controller's reports between contacts, watches the controller, and restores it when its firmware cannot run.

Controller Runs its firmware, acts on commands, reports its state, and returns to working firmware on its own when new firmware fails.

The ground station's radio equipment and the spacecraft power supply are outside the System; it uses them as given.

3.3 Interfaces

External interfaces

Operator interface Human. Ground software to operator. Allows the flight operator to issue telecommands, authorize firmware deployments, and monitor system telemetry.

Radio link Radio frequency. Ground software to onboard computer via external radio equipment. Provides intermittent telemetry and telecommand (TM/TC) transfer exclusively during contact windows.

Power Electrical. Spacecraft power subsystem to onboard computer and controller. Subject to unannounced power interruptions at any time (assumption A-2).

Interfaces between elements

Data link Digital data. Onboard computer to controller. Nominal interface for commands, telemetry, and firmware updates while controller firmware is running. Uses two separate connections, so a single connection failure does not interrupt operations.

Reprogramming link Digital data. Onboard computer to controller. Recovery interface used as a last resort to restore functional firmware independently of the controller's main software.

3.4 Modes of Operations

Life-cycle modes of the System

Test Ground bench execution with simulated radio link degradation and intentional fault injection to demonstrate operational scenarios.

Operation Active mission execution using the controller modes detailed below.

Disposal Not applicable; limited to bench demonstration scope.

Controller modes during operation

OPERATE Nominal state executing confirmed firmware. New firmware images can be staged in the background during execution [**TBR-6**].

TRIAL Entered upon transitioning to updated firmware. Executes the new image for a bounded evaluation window [**TBD-6**]. If the new image is judged good, the update is committed and the controller returns to OPERATE; if not, it enters FALLBACK.

FALLBACK Entered following a failed firmware trial or boot failure. Reverts execution to the previous known-good firmware image or the last-resort firmware.

RECOVERY Entered when no operational firmware image can be executed. Controller software execution is halted while the onboard computer restores functional firmware via the reprogramming link.

3.5 Proposed Capabilities

Telemetry (serves G-2 Observability)

Telemetry-1 Send regular health reports: alive or not, firmware version, time since start, reason for the last restart, temperature [**TBR-4**].

Telemetry-2 Send a report as soon as something important happens [**TBR-4**].

Telemetry-3 Timestamp every report [**TBR-4**].
Telemetry-4 Store reports between contacts and send them all at the next contact; report any that were lost.
Telemetry-5 Report the health of each data-link connection [**TBR-4**].

Commands (serves G-1 Operability)
Command-1 Accept commands only from the operator; refuse copies of old commands sent again.
Command-2 Answer every command: received, refused with the reason, or done with the result.
Command-3 Refuse a command that is not allowed in the current mode.
Command-4 Run a command that arrives twice only once.
Command-5 Require two steps for a dangerous command: arm, then execute.
Command-6 Refuse commands with impossible values.
Command-7 Let the operator cancel an update in progress, leaving working firmware running.
Command-8 Run commands at a time the operator sets; refuse commands that waited past their expiry.
Command-9 Log every command and its answer.

Fault handling (serves G-1 Operability) [**TBR-5**]
Fault-1 Notice when the controller goes silent and try to bring it back.
Fault-2 Continue over the other data-link connection when one fails.
Fault-3 Restart onboard programs that crash, and continue where they stopped.
Fault-4 Record every fault found and the action taken, for the ground.

Update (serves G-3 Correctability)
Update-1 Receive firmware from the ground even when the radio link keeps dropping.
Update-2 Refuse firmware that is damaged, not from the operator, built for another controller, or older than the minimum version.
Update-3 Deliver new firmware to the controller.
Update-4 Switch the controller to the new firmware. When the switch happens is still open [**TBD-3**].
Update-5 Judge whether the new firmware is good. Who judges is still open [**TBD-4**].
Update-6 If the new firmware is not good, return the controller to working firmware without outside help.
Update-7 Report the outcome of every update to the ground.

Test (verification only)
Test-1 Degrade the radio link on purpose.
Test-2 On command, cut the controller's power or break one data-link connection [**TBR-10**].

Disposal: none; bench demonstration.

4.0 Physical Environment

Follows from the situation in which nobody can reach the System. Response legend [1, App. S, p. 252]: OPERATE = all functions continue; SURVIVE = functions stop and return when the condition ends.

Condition	Response	Scenario
No ground contact	OPERATE	Scenario-110
Controller power loss at any instant	SURVIVE	Scenario-340
Single-bit memory error	OPERATE	Scenario-400
Temperature range	**[TBD-9]**	—

5.0 Support Environment

Firmware is built and released on the ground and sent up during contacts, one transfer across several if needed. The onboard computer keeps the last known-good firmware. Update rate **[TBD-8]**. Nothing is repaired after deployment.

6.0 Operational Scenarios

Every scenario below is demonstrated on hardware and recorded.

6.1 Nominal Conditions

Scenario-100 Update: release, upload over one or more contacts, check, transfer **[TBR-6]**, switch **[TBD-3]**, judged good **[TBD-4]**, confirmed, outcome reported.

Scenario-110 Telemetry: reports stamped and stored between contacts, all sent at the next one.

Scenario-120 Scheduled command: received during a contact, runs at its time, answer sent at the next contact.

6.2 Off-Nominal Conditions

Trigger, then expected outcome. Sources in brackets are items of [2, App. A, Table 2].

Scenario-200 Ground link lost mid-transfer: resumes next contact where it stopped.

Scenario-210 Command not from operator or replayed: refused, logged [2, p. 62].

Scenario-220 Answer lost, command resent: not run again, “already done”.

Scenario-230 Command wrong for current state: refused with reason [2, p. 63].

Scenario-240 Impossible value: refused with reason [2, p. 62].

Scenario-250 Dangerous command not armed: refused with reason.

Scenario-260 Command expired: refused with reason [2, p. 63].

Scenario-270 Report storage full: ground told how many were lost.

Scenario-300 Firmware damaged in transfer: refused before the controller [2, p. 63].

Scenario-310 Firmware not from operator: refused.

Scenario-320 Firmware below minimum version: refused.

Scenario-330 Firmware for another controller: refused [2, p. 63].

Scenario-340 Power lost during firmware write: previous firmware runs; retry possible [2, p. 63].

Scenario-350 New firmware hangs: back to previous, unaided.

Scenario-360 New firmware restart loop: back to previous after **[TBD-7]** starts [2, p. 64].

Scenario-370 New firmware never judged good: back to previous.

Scenario-380 Previous firmware also bad: last-resort firmware runs.

Scenario-390 Operator cancels update: known-good firmware left running.

Scenario-400 Bit error in stored firmware: detected, not run **[TBR-9]** [2, p. 63].

Scenario-410 No firmware can run: restored through the reprogramming link [2, p. 63].

Scenario-500 One data-link connection fails: everything continues on the other; reported.

Scenario-510 Both data-link connections fail: controller keeps working; loss reported; reprogramming link still usable [**TBR-8**].
Scenario-520 Controller silent: noticed, recovery tried, recorded [**TBR-5**].
Scenario-530 Onboard program crash: it restarts and resumes any update; the controller is unaffected [**TBR-5**].

7.0 Impact Considerations

Not applicable: bench demonstration.

8.0 Risks and Potential Issues

R-1 Both data-link connections may share software; one defect could cut both.
R-2 Controller memory may not hold last-resort plus two working firmwares.
R-3 Second data-link connection and reprogramming link not yet shown on bench.
R-4 Demonstration date [**TBD-2**]; undemonstrated scenarios are declared, not dropped.

A Acronyms

ConOps Concept of Operations
MOC Mission operations center
TBD To Be Determined
TBR To Be Resolved
TC Telecommand
TM Telemetry

B Glossary

Confirmed Firmware judged good after its trial; only confirmed firmware is known-good.
Last-resort Known-good firmware that updates never replace (golden image).
Switch The controller stops running old firmware and starts the new.
Arm First step of a dangerous command; changes nothing alone.
Expiry Time after which a waiting command is refused.

C Open Items

Unmarked statements were stated or accepted by the author on 9–10 October 2026. TBR items are resolved before the hazard analysis.

Resolved

TBR-1 Spacecraft controller, ground contacts only, no physical access, bench stand-in, bit errors occur, no repair. Accepted by the author, 10 October 2026.
TBR-2 Controller power can drop at any instant, including mid-write. Accepted by the author, 10 October 2026.
TBR-3 One operator. Accepted by the author, 10 October 2026.

Open

TBR-4 Telemetry-1, Telemetry-2, Telemetry-3, Telemetry-5 as written (shown 10 Oct, not yet accepted).
TBR-5 O-4 and Fault-1 to Fault-4 as written (shown 10 Oct, not yet accepted).
TBR-6 Controller keeps working while new firmware arrives.
TBR-7 Onboard computer's own update out of scope.
TBR-8 Reprogramming link still usable with both data-link connections lost.
TBR-9 Stored firmware checked before start; damaged copy skipped.
TBR-10 Test setup can cut power and break one connection.
TBD-1 Project name and document reference.
TBD-2 Demonstration date.
TBD-3 Switch automatically on arrival, or only on operator command.
TBD-4 Who judges new firmware good: controller or operator.
TBD-5 Contact window length and gap (sourced, or a test parameter).
TBD-6 Trial time limit (requirements).
TBD-7 Failed starts before going back (requirements).
TBD-8 Update rate.
TBD-9 Temperature range.